

1 · The rubric: 6 points

Thesis (1)	a defensible claim with a line of reasoning, in one place (intro or conclusion); not the prompt restated
Context (1)	broader developments before, during or after the prompt's years, tied to the topic; not just a phrase
Evidence (2)	1: identify two specific examples. 2: use two to support the argument
Analysis (2)	1: causation, comparison or change and continuity frames the essay. 2: a complex understanding built into the argument

Identify vs use. "The Stamp Act (1765) taxed printed paper" names it. Add "..., and colonists answered with the Stamp Act Congress, which shows war debt turning into organized resistance" and it supports a claim.

Routes to complexity: weigh several causes; show both cause and effect, or both change and continuity; connect to another period; use four or more pieces of evidence for a nuanced argument; show different perspectives.

2 · The chain (causation)

1754 to 1763	French and Indian War: Britain wins, France leaves, Britain deep in debt
1763	Treaty of Paris; Pontiac's Rebellion; Proclamation of 1763 (land, not a tax)
1764 to 1767	Sugar, Stamp, Townshend: revenue taxes. Currency Act: monetary restrictions.
1765 to 1773	boycotts, Sons of Liberty, Stamp Act Congress, Committees of Correspondence, Tea Party
1774	Coercive Acts unite the colonies; First Continental Congress, still loyal
1775	Lexington and Concord; Second Continental Congress; Olive Branch Petition refused
1776	Common Sense , then the Declaration of Independence
1777 to 1778	Saratoga helps secure the French alliance (1778)
1781	Yorktown: the decisive surrender
1783	Treaty of Paris: independence recognized, border at the Mississippi

3 · Colonial society, 1720 to 1760

- Population grew about tenfold from 1700 to 1775, mostly by **natural increase**.
- Newcomers: enslaved Africans (the largest group, forced migrants); Germans and Scots-Irish, most after 1730, many to the backcountry.
- First Great Awakening** (1730s to 1740s): Jonathan Edwards, George Whitefield; New Lights vs Old Lights; more denominations and toleration; authority questioned.
- Continuity: still loyal British subjects in 1760; slavery grew.

4 · Ideas behind the resistance

- Virtual** representation (Britain): Parliament speaks for all subjects. **Actual** representation (colonists): only elected assemblies can tax.
- Trade regulation acceptable; taxes for revenue not.
- Real Whigs:** power threatens liberty. **John Locke:** natural rights and consent, the base of the Declaration.
- 1775: rights as Englishmen. 1776: natural rights and independence.

5 · Best evidence by argument

to argue	use
Britain's policy caused the break	Sugar Act 1764; Stamp Act 1765; Declaratory Act 1766; Townshend 1767; Coercive Acts 1774
colonies became united	Albany Plan rejected 1754, then Stamp Act Congress 1765, Committees of Correspondence 1772, First Continental Congress 1774
goals changed	Rights and Grievances 1774, Olive Branch 1775, then Common Sense and the Declaration 1776
ideas mattered	actual representation; Real Whigs; Locke; Common Sense
society changed first	natural increase; German and Scots-Irish immigration; Great Awakening
why the colonists won	Saratoga 1777 and the French alliance 1778; Washington avoided decisive losses; home ground; Yorktown 1781
limits of the Revolution	Dunmore's Proclamation 1775; Loyalists and Native nations unresolved in 1783

Traps

- 1763 Treaty of Paris ends the French and Indian War; 1783 ends the Revolution.
- Yorktown (1781) is the decisive surrender; independence is recognized in 1783.
- Saratoga (1777) did not end the war; it helped bring the French alliance (1778).
- Rights and Grievances (1774) is loyal; the Declaration of Independence (1776) is the break.
- The Proclamation of 1763 is a land rule, not a tax. The Sugar Act lowered the duty.
- The Declaration blames the king, not Parliament.
- Avoid "always" and "never"; keep evidence inside 1720 to 1783 unless it is labeled context or a connection.

6 · Planning a paragraph (any prompt)

- Claim that answers the prompt, using its reasoning word.
- Two specific, dated pieces of evidence.
- After each: "This shows ..." tied back to the thesis.
- Close with the paragraph's link to the next reason.

7 · Self-check

Does the thesis answer the prompt with a defensible position and a line of reasoning, together in one place?	☐
Does the context explain broader developments before, during or after the period and connect them to the prompt?	☐
Is every piece of evidence specific (name and year) and followed by what it shows?	☐
Does each body paragraph explain causation, comparison or change, not just narrate?	☐
Is the complexity part of the argument and backed with evidence?	☐
Dates checked: 1763 vs 1783, 1775 vs 1776, 1781 vs 1783?	☐

Quick recall: cover the right column of section 2 and say each step from its year, then say why each step caused the next. Then name one piece of evidence for each row of section 5 without looking.

Not verified: the real prompt, the time limit, how many prompts you choose from, and what aids are allowed. The prompts in the guide are practice only.